

FY26, as the books stood in June

Generated 2026-09-02 from `sources/analyses/fy26-closeout.md`. Every figure is recomputed from `sources/data/lunenburg.db` by `scripts/verify_fy26_closeout.py`. A printed page outlives the numbers on it: re-run that script before quoting anything here.

Working state: `notes/HANDOFF.md` carries the current branch and what is established versus assumed.
`CLAUDE.md` carries the rules.

Analysis, 2 September 2026. Every figure recomputed by `scripts/verify_fy26_closeout.py` from `sources/data/lunenburg.db`.

Each section is written twice: **In plain terms** for anyone, and **The evidence** for anyone who wants to check it. The plain version never states anything the evidence does not support.

What this rests on, and what it is not

On 2 September 2026 the Town Manager sent the FY26 year-to-date budget report in two forms, printed and as a spreadsheet. It is the **first account-level general fund expenditure report this project has ever held**. Every prior one was run as a department rollup, which renders the entire school district as a single row.

Here the school department is **258 accounts**, each with an org code, an object code and a description.

Three limits travel with every figure below, and none of them is a technicality.

It is period 12, not period 13. Period 12 is June. Period 13 is the year-end close, after purchase orders are cleared in the lapse period. The Town Manager said so in the covering note: the figures *"are likely to continue to adjust as we continue the year-end reconciliation process."* In FY25 that step moved the school figure by \$21,770.53 between two School Committee meetings a fortnight apart. **So nothing here is a surplus. It is a position.**

Zero-balance accounts are suppressed. The report was run with `Suppress zero bal accts: Y`. An account absent from it is not necessarily absent from the ledger, and nothing below reasons from what is missing.

It is expenditures only, Fund 0100. No grants, no revolving funds, no school choice. The district's budget is *net* — a line is what the town must raise after other money has paid for part of the thing — so none of this says what anything costs.

1. The headline number is a residual, not a result

IN PLAIN TERMS

The school department was **\$482,101 under budget** in June. That single number is the small remainder of two much larger flows running in opposite directions: about \$1.68 million unspent across 160 accounts, and about \$1.20 million overspent across 56.

Reading \$482,101 as "the schools underspent by half a million" describes the arithmetic correctly and the year not at all.

THE EVIDENCE

Original appropriation	\$26,247,474.00
Transfers and adjustments	\$85,090.24
Revised budget	\$26,332,564.24
Expended	\$25,613,679.23
Encumbered	\$236,783.89
Unspent	\$482,101.12

	ACCOUNTS	AMOUNT
Under their revised budget	160	\$1,683,534.14
Over their revised budget	56	\$1,201,433.65
Net	258	\$482,101.12

Town-wide at the same period: \$51,189,965.10 appropriated, \$2,826,046.42 transferred, \$52,163,984.85 spent, \$529,325.69 encumbered, **\$1,322,700.98 unspent**.

The Town's own release of 1 September 2026 put the school figure at "approximately \$470,000 to \$600,000" and the town-wide figure at "roughly \$1.63 million". The school figure here sits inside that range near the bottom. **The town-wide figures differ and are not reconciled here** — the release is preliminary, this is one report at one period, and nothing published says how the release's figure was struck.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT SHOW

Whether any of it survives the close. Encumbrances of \$236,783.89 are still open, and clearing purchase orders releases some of that back and commits the rest.

2. The biggest movers

IN PLAIN TERMS

Two out-of-district special education lines account for most of the movement in both directions, and they move opposite ways. Beneath them sit one of the district's four psychologist accounts that spent nothing all year, a utility overrun, and paraprofessional lines that all ran over.

THE EVIDENCE

ACCOUNT		REVISED	SPENT	ENCUMBERED	LEFT
S0511062	SPED PRIVA — out-of-district, private	\$988,630	\$466,001	\$0	+\$522,629
S5511062	COLL TUITI — out-of-district, collaborative	\$302,663	\$678,062	\$58,708	-\$434,108
S3991742	ELEC CHGS — electricity	\$271,132	\$319,109	\$62,362	-\$110,338
S1511062	CONT SERV — special services contracted	\$105,500	\$204,758	\$1,262	-\$100,520
S2072061	PSYCHSALAR — one of four psychologist accounts, \$4	\$98,784	\$0	\$0	+\$98,784
S2032121	KINDAIDREG — kindergarten paras	\$0	\$93,691	\$0	-\$93,691
S3991692	SPED TRANS — special ed transport	\$565,735	\$620,025	\$13,265	-\$67,555
4 accounts	special education paraprofessionals	\$1,352,508	\$1,458,152	\$0	-\$105,644

The last column is revised – spent – encumbered, **not** revised – spent, and the encumbrance column is printed because without it the arithmetic does not appear to work. COLL TUITI is the clearest case: \$302,663 – \$678,062 is \$375,399, and the figure is \$434,108, because \$58,708 is committed under purchase orders that have not yet been paid. An earlier version of this table showed the variance and omitted the encumbrance it was computed from.

An encumbrance is money promised under a signed contract and not yet paid out. At the year-end close some of it is paid and the rest is released back, which is exactly the step this report predates.

The two out-of-district lines together: \$1,291,293 budgeted, \$1,144,063 spent, a net of +\$88,522.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT SHOW

Why the two out-of-district lines moved in opposite directions. It is tempting to read a shift from private placements toward collaboratives. That precise inference — two budget lines moving in opposite directions by similar amounts — is one of the three errors CLAUDE.md records as having shipped here before being caught. What is established is the two numbers. Placement counts by year are not published, so dollars cannot distinguish fewer children from a different mix from a differently struck budget.

Whether the special education paraprofessional overruns mean more staff. They are dollars. A budget line is not a filled position.

3. Kindergarten paraprofessionals — an open question

IN PLAIN TERMS

The FY26 approved budget cut the kindergarten paraprofessional line to zero and published it as a **–100% cut**. During FY26, **\$99,064 was spent on kindergarten paraprofessionals anyway**, against an appropriation of nothing and with no transfer covering it. In February 2026, while that spending was happening, the district asked for a kindergarten paraprofessional back as a **new** staffing request for FY27, at \$22,205. It did not make the FY27 proposed budget.

No meeting document connects either the cut or the spending to a decision. Kindergarten paraprofessionals do appear in the minutes — twice — and both times as an FY27 staffing request, never in relation to FY26. The distinction matters and an earlier draft of this section did not make it.

This is not presented as an impropriety. Money is routinely spent and reconciled later through a year-end transfer, and the FY26 transfer schedule is exactly what we do not have.

THE EVIDENCE

The cut, published. FY26 School Committee approved budget, 12 March 2025, page 7, under 2330 – Paraprofessionals General Education:

Kindergarten Paraprofessionals	77,699.88\$	73,273.00\$	(73,273.00)\$	–100.00%	(73,273.00)\$
–100.00%					
H.S. Paraprofessionals /Regular	18,435.23\$	47,960.00\$	(47,960.00)\$	–100.00%	(47,960.00)\$
–100.00%					

The history, from the FY27 workbook (fy27-proposals.xlsx, sheet FY27 Budget Projection, and identical in its traceable twin):

CELL		VALUE
C332	FY23 actual	\$75,501.66
D332	FY24 actual	\$77,699.88
E332	FY25 actual	\$83,765.97
F332	FY25 budget	\$73,273.00
G332	FY26 final budget	–
J332 – M332	every FY27 proposal	–

Row 333, Kindergarten Aides/Regular, exists only from FY26: G333 = 0, H333 = 59,709.10 of actuals to date. **That row is the ledger account surfacing in the workbook, not a renamed budget line** — it does not appear in the FY26 approved budget at all.

The spending, from the ledger at period 12:

ACCOUNT	OBJECT	ORIGINAL	TRANSFERS	REVISED	SPENT
S2032121 KINDAIDREG	511103	\$0	\$0	\$0	\$93,691.03
S2032131 KINDPARREG	511203	\$0	\$0	\$0	\$5,373.12

\$99,064.15 against an appropriation of \$0.

The mechanism exists and was used elsewhere. Nine school accounts spent with no original appropriation. Six received a transfer to cover it — HS GUID SE \$42,967, DUES/FEES \$29,965, PHYS ED SU \$550 among them. These two received nothing.

The request, in the minutes. Finance Committee, 26 February 2026, under *Staffing Increase Requests — Primary School*:

1 Interventionist to address the early literacy and math gaps: \$72,441
1 Kindergarten Paraprofessional: \$22,205

and, in the same list, *"The above listed position costs do not include insurance costs."* A resident named the same request in public comment to the School Committee on 10 March 2026.

Both mentions are FY27 requests. Neither refers to the FY26 cut or to the FY26 spending. That is the whole of what the minutes say.

A PARTIAL CONCLUSION, OFFERED AS ONE

The service continued. Kindergarten paraprofessionals were paid throughout FY26 at a level comparable to prior years — \$99,064 against actuals of \$75,502, \$77,700 and \$83,766 in the three years before — while the line carrying them was budgeted at zero.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT SHOW, AND THREE READINGS THAT FIT EQUALLY WELL

1. **A recoding.** The appropriation landed under a different line and the spending did not follow it. H.S. Paraprofessionals /Regular was cut the same way and shows *no* FY26 spending, so the cut was real somewhere; it is not established that it was real here.
2. **A grant expected to cover it.** The Town has stated that about \$287,000 of out-of-district tuition was charged to the FY26 IDEA grant rather than the operating budget, so grant-shifting demonstrably happened in FY26. Nothing links it to this line.
3. **An unreconciled overrun** awaiting the year-end transfer that has not yet been voted.

Do not treat the \$22,205 request as the cost of the FY26 spending. It is one position, excluding insurance, in a different fiscal year. $\$99,064 \div \$22,205$ is arithmetic, not a headcount.

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

The FY26 year-end transfer schedule, by department and account, with the authority for each. And Finance Committee minutes from 14 July 2026 onward.

4. Four psychologist lines, and one of them spent nothing

IN PLAIN TERMS

The district carries four school psychologist accounts and four social worker accounts, one per building. **Three of the four psychologist lines spent their budget in full or a little over. The fourth spent nothing at all, all year — \$98,784 budgeted, \$0 out.**

The social worker lines are less stark but point the same way: two spent in full, one spent 68%, one spent 23%.

Between them the eight accounts left \$194,718 unspent, which is about 40% of the department's entire net underspend.

THE EVIDENCE

ACCOUNT		BUDGETED	SPENT	
S2044061	PSYCHSALAR	\$98,784	\$101,510	103%
S2055061	PSYCHSALAR	\$45,106	\$45,306	100%
S2066061	PSYCHSALAR	\$45,106	\$45,306	100%
S2072061	PSYCHSALAR	\$98,784	\$0	0%
four psychologist accounts		\$287,780	\$192,122	
S2044651	SOCWORKSAL	\$92,939	\$92,939	100%
S2055651	SOCWORKSAL	\$92,939	\$63,214	68%
S2066651	SOCWORKSAL	\$90,212	\$20,877	23%
S2072651	SOCWORKSAL	\$92,939	\$92,939	100%
four social worker accounts		\$369,029	\$269,969	

All eight carry object code 511023 or 511024, and none received a transfer.

WHY IT MATTERS BEYOND THE MONEY

CLAUDE.md lists as a standing question: *"Whether budgeted positions were filled. A budget line is an intention."* For these eight lines, in this one year, the ledger comes closer to answering it than anything this project has held before — three lines paid in full look like filled posts, and one paid nothing does not.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT SHOW

That a post was vacant. A line spending nothing is consistent with a vacancy, with a person paid from a different account, with a grant-funded position, or with a coding change. Rule 7: the measurement is the dollars.

And it is deliberately not stated as "a school psychologist was cut". An earlier draft of this section quoted the zero line alone and described it as *a position budgeted and not spent*, which read as a statement about the district's psychologists in general. It is one of four. `scripts/verify_fy26_closeout.py` caught it because the figure it derived from the database did not match the figure in the prose.

5. \$85,090 moved into the schools, and no vote is on the record

IN PLAIN TERMS

The ledger shows \$85,090.24 of transfers into the school department during FY26. The Finance Committee took up year-end transfers twice and no minutes exist in this archive for either meeting.

THE EVIDENCE

Finance Committee, 11 June 2026:

"a. Year End Transfers — The documents needed on this topic were not provided but should be available for the next meeting."

It returned to the agenda for 14 July 2026. The archive holds Finance Committee **agendas** through 27 August 2026 and **minutes** only through 11 June 2026. Four meetings have an agenda and no minutes, and the first of them is the one that took up transfers.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT SHOW

That no vote happened. Minutes may not be posted yet, and not every transfer requires a Finance Committee vote. What can be said is that **no document in this archive connects any dollar of movement to a decision.**

6. What none of this can see

\$1,736,376 was spent on the schools in FY26 from 61 funds outside the general fund — school lunch, extended day, the IDEA grants, athletics, after-school. **Not one dollar of it can be attached to a budget line,** because no published document maps a fund's spending onto the district's lines.

So every figure above is the **town's share**. A line that fell may mean less service, or may mean a grant paid for it. The expense side cannot tell them apart, and neither can this document.

What would change these findings

In order of how much each would settle:

1. **The FY26 period 13 report.** Turns every figure here from a position into a result.
2. **The year-end transfer schedule,** by account, with authority. Settles §3 and §5.
3. **The same report for funds other than 0100.** Turns the net budget into a gross one.
4. **Finance Committee minutes from 14 July 2026.**
5. **Out-of-district placement counts by year.** The only thing that would let §2's two tuition lines be read as anything other than two numbers.

How to reproduce

```
python3 scripts/build_db.py
python3 scripts/verify_fy26_closeout.py
```